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## Flock says its cameras don't track people. Its own training videos say otherwise.

Company's newest devices use AI to follow pedestrians, while protesters are mapping nearly 90,000 surveillance cameras nationwide.

Flock's own training videos show police using the system to track suspects "from location to location to location."

By [Brendan Keefe](#)

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([InvestigateTV](#)) — [Flock Safety](#) says its cameras don't track people.

But the company's own training videos show police using the system to track suspects "from location to location to location."

And some of its cameras are designed to follow people as they walk.

"And they quite literally use AI to zoom in and follow you around whether you're a person of interest or not," said [Benn Jordan](#), a security researcher who found dozens of Flock cameras streaming openly online.

This is the second report in an [ongoing investigation](#) into Flock Safety, a private Atlanta-based company that operates a network of surveillance cameras used by thousands of police departments nationwide.

**[Read: Flock Safety cameras help solve crimes. But who's watching the watchers?](#)**

## Tracking the trackers

Inside a coffee shop in Boulder, Colorado, Will Freeman runs the largest police camera tracking system in the nation.

It's called [DeFlock](#).

The app shows where Flock cameras are located and which direction they're pointed.

"How many cameras have you mapped?" our national investigator Brendan Keefe asked.

"88,970 cameras at the moment," Freeman said.

Freeman said he created the app to show people how invasive the surveillance network has become.

Flock license plate readers take a time-stamped photo of every vehicle that passes. Police can search historical travel information for any car for 30 days without a warrant.

“If you were to build a graph of that sheet and plot it to a map, now it’s as if you’ve had a GPS on your car for an entire month,” Jordan said.

## **The tracking debate**

Josh Thomas, Flock Safety’s chief communications officer, said the company helps solve 700,000 crimes a year.

“Reported crimes in America, yeah,” Thomas said. “So there’s a lot more that probably are being helped that aren’t being reported. But yes, we have about 700,000 crimes that we are aware of that are being solved, in part with evidence that’s derived from a Flock Safety device.”

But Thomas disputed the characterization that the system tracks people. Thomas said the system captures fixed points in time, not continuous tracking.

“Tracking the whole of your movements is very different than knowing that you pass by one specific camera, 24 specific cameras,” Thomas said. “Those are different things.”

## **Flock’s own training videos**

But Flock’s own webinars describe the system’s ability to track vehicles and people.

“The example of tracking that vehicle from location to location to location,” a Flock webinar instructor said.

“And you’re able to track your suspect’s movements,” another webinar showed.

In one training video, a police officer described using Flock cameras to follow a suspect across

“And we were able to track him all the way over to another state, in Kentucky,” the officer said.

## **Condor cameras track pedestrians**

Flock’s Condor cameras are different from its license plate readers.

The Condor is a pan-tilt-zoom camera that uses artificial intelligence to detect and follow people.

“You’re saying Flock does not track people, correct?” National investigator Brendan Keefe asked Thomas.

“Track people? That’s right,” Thomas said. “And the whole of their movements, like you asked, we’re not tracking people.”

“But what do the Condor cameras do? They literally are designed to track a person, aren’t they?” Keefe asked.

“Not to track a person, no,” Thomas said.

But when Keefe walked in front of a Condor camera on a public trail, the camera followed his movements in real time, panning and tilting to keep him in frame.

A Flock training webinar describes the feature.

“To alert you when it sees human movement,” the webinar instructor said. “And it will actually acquire and track that person as they walk, or people.”

Thomas said the camera has an object detection feature called Guardian Mode.

“There’s an object detection feature that you can set up. it’s called Guardian Mode. that allows

not tracking where you're going to go, where you're going to leave, or you're going to start and stop."

Jordan said the Condor cameras appeared shortly after Flock said its cameras only record license plates.

"These started popping up weeks after hearing Flock say, 'These only record license plates. They don't take pictures of people,'" Jordan said.

The Condor is a pan-tilt-zoom camera that uses A.I. to detect and follow people. (InvestigateTV)

## Cameras streaming without passwords

Jordan found the same Condor camera streaming openly online with no password required. He [published the video on YouTube](#) along 404 Media.

"At one point, I think we had found over 70 cameras," Jordan said.

Jordan said he was able to watch people in real time.

"I watched a man leave his house in the morning. I watched a woman jogging alone on a forest trail in Georgia," Jordan said.

Jordan was able to read a statement from Flock's CEO about the company never being hacked in front of one of the exposed cameras. He downloaded the footage later over the internet, directly from the camera.

Thomas said the exposure was an accident caused by Verizon.

"This wasn't the dark web," Keefe said. "This was openly streaming to anyone who could go on a specific search engine and scan open ports. Was that an accident?"

"Yes," Thomas said. "Verizon sent us the wrong SIM cards that had a public IP address. We have a lot of sensors in the world that don't have that. Roughly 60-70 devices had a public-

Verizon did not respond to a request for comment.

## Officers arrested for misuse

Police officers nationwide have been arrested for using Flock cameras to stalk former partners and love interests.

“What if a police officer uses Flock cameras to stalk their ex? What if an abusive partner uses it to stalk their ex-girlfriend and her new boyfriend? It’s already happened,” Jordan said.

Thomas said misuse is a horrible use of the technology.

“Tools aren’t designed to do that,” Thomas said. “This is why we built an audit log, and we work with the appropriate democratically elected governing bodies to hold those people accountable.”

Freeman said abuse is inevitable.

“You have to consider human nature when you implement things like this,” Freeman said. “No one’s perfect. People are going to abuse it.”

## Routing around cameras

Back in the Boulder coffee shop, Freeman demonstrated another feature of DeFlock.

“Direct route, four cameras,” Freeman said, showing a 1.7-mile route. “And that’s just to go 1.7 miles.”

Will Freeman shows how the app DeFlock suggests alternate routes to avoid Flock cameras (InvestigateTV)

DeFlock allows users to plot routes that avoid cameras. The app showed an alternate route that

“Yeah, it goes from five minutes to 14 minutes, but it avoids all the cameras,” Freeman said.

## **The debate over public safety**

Thomas said the technology helps prevent mass killings.

“There’s an epidemic, as we all know, of mass killings in America,” Thomas said. “And if there’s an opportunity to stop that, I want to be on the side of the people who are fighting to stop those things, not the people who are fighting to stop the proliferation of technology to stop crime.”

“Actual killers have been caught with this technology,” Keefe said to Freeman. “Would you want to take that away from the police?”

“Considering everything, I would want to take that away from the police, at least in the current state that it’s in,” Freeman said.

Freeman said the problem is that the system logs everyone, not just suspects.

“A feature that you can’t turn off is that it’s logging everyone else,” Freeman said. “So if they can get rid of that ‘logging everyone else’ part, I think it would be a lot better.”

Freeman said he will continue tracking the trackers because no one is watching the watchers.

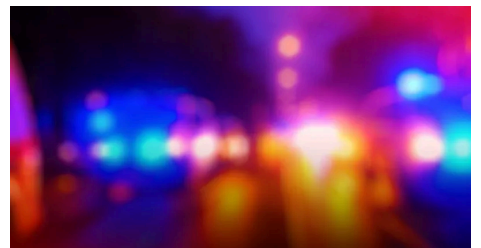
More than two dozen cities recently cancelled their Flock contracts, including Denver, amid concerns over who has access to the company’s camera data.

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